

3.1.2 Section B: Ethics and religion

Students must develop knowledge and understanding of the following:

- the meaning and significance of the specified content
- the influence of these beliefs and teachings on individuals, communities and societies
- the cause and significance of similarities and differences in beliefs and teachings
- the approach of philosophy to the study of religion and belief.

The term 'belief(s)' includes religious beliefs and non-religious beliefs as appropriate.

They should be able to analyse and evaluate issues arising from the topics studied, and the views and arguments of the scholars prescribed for study.

Students should also be able to use specialist language and terminology appropriately.

Questions may be set that span more than one topic.

Normative ethical theories

- Deontological: natural moral law and the principle of double effect with reference to Aquinas; proportionalism.
- Teleological: situation ethics with reference to Fletcher.
- Character based: virtue ethics with reference to Aristotle.
- The differing approaches taken to moral decision making by these ethical theories.
- Their application to the issues of theft and lying.
- The strengths and weaknesses of these ways of making moral decisions.

The application of natural moral law, situation ethics and virtue ethics to:

- Issues of human life and death:
 - embryo research; cloning; 'designer' babies
 - abortion
 - voluntary euthanasia and assisted suicide
 - capital punishment.
- Issues of non-human life and death:
 - use of animals as food; intensive farming
 - use of animals in scientific procedures; cloning
 - blood sports
 - animals as a source of organs for transplants.

Introduction to meta ethics: the meaning of right and wrong

- Divine Command Theory – right is what God commands, wrong is what God forbids.
- Naturalism: Utilitarianism – right is what causes pleasure, wrong is what causes pain.
- Non-naturalism: Intuitionism – moral values are self-evident.
- The strengths and weaknesses of these ideas.

Free will and moral responsibility

- The conditions of moral responsibility: free will; understanding the difference between right and wrong.
- The extent of moral responsibility: libertarianism, hard determinism, compatibilism.
- The relevance of moral responsibility to reward and punishment.

Conscience

- Differing ideas, religious and non-religious, about the nature of conscience.
- The role of conscience in making moral decisions with reference to:
 - telling lies and breaking promises
 - adultery.
- The value of conscience as a moral guide.

Bentham and Kant

- Comparison of the key ideas of Bentham and Kant about moral decision making.
- How far these two ethical theories are consistent with religious moral decision making.